

MEETING MANDELA

The Queen was glad to see South Africa rejoin the Commonwealth in 1994 after the Apartheid years of white-only rule. On a visit in 1995, she met the country's new president, Nelson Mandela, freed after years in prison. He made a state visit to the UK a year later and returned in 2008 when he was 90. The Queen phoned him with birthday greetings, a sign of their easy friendship.



Tony Blair

The Commonwealth was also changing. Elizabeth visited South Africa for the first time since 1947 and met Nelson Mandela. Two years later, she was in India and Pakistan to mark 50 years since the end of British rule. The two countries were now republics.

Elizabeth celebrated her 70th birthday in 1996 and a year later gained a new prime minister, Tony Blair. People began talking about